

CHIEF MINISTER VS GOVERNOR

As in other Opposition-ruled states, CM Mann and Governor Banwarilal Purohit are at loggerheads in Punjab too

Sept. 2022 Purohit refuses Mann request for a one-day special assembly session to seek a confidence motion, stymied amid rumours of an 'Operation Lotus'

CM Mann hits out at the governor's "intransigence", calls it attack on democracy. Days later, governor gives assent, AAP wins round

Oct. Purohit urges government to rescind appointment of Dr S.S. Gosal as V-C of Punjab Agricultural University, calls his appointment 'illegal'

Mann ignores advice, asks Dr Gosal to continue

Dec. Guv wants Chandigarh SSP Kuldeep Singh Chahal removed for alleged "misconduct". A CBI enquiry also initiated

AAP lets issue hang. A day before R-Day function in Jan. 2023, AAP govt appoints him Police Commissioner, Jalandhar, where Purohit was chief guest

Feb. 1, 2023 Purohit visits border districts of Punjab, finds top police officers missing

The same day, Mann schedules meeting of all Deputy Commissioners and Senior Superintendents of Police (SSPs) in Chandigarh

Feb. 14 Purohit questions appointment of educationist Gurinderjit Singh Jawanda as Punjab Information and Communication Technology Corporation Ltd chairman, alleges that his name figures in a kidnapping and land grab case

Mann chooses not to reply

Feb. 14 Guv asks CM to explain process of selecting 36 government school principals for a training seminar held in Singapore

Mann writes back asking Purohit to explain the process by which governors are elected. Says 30 million Punjabis want to know how he has been elected

Feb. 26 Governor seeks answers to various queries raised in four letters before giving nod for budget session, alleges that Mann's letter is 'unconstitutional and derogatory'

AAP moves apex court to seek directions. On Feb. 28, SC says governor must have access to information, but also says he must follow recommendations of cabinet on convening assembly session

by around 14 per cent every year. In January, the state power utility took a Rs 500 crore debt to pay salaries to its staff and other dues. In his first meeting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Mann had demanded a fiscal package to bail out the state, but the Centre has so far refused. If its revenues do not pick up, Punjab's finances will turn precipitous.

On their part, AAP says the state's finances are the legacy of the previous governments that have looted the exchequer. Says the AAP source, "We are cognisant of the fiscal health of the state and working towards a plan that essentially includes restructuring debt, identifying additional revenue streams and also ensuring proper compliance through technological interventions to increase collection through existing sources."

HOW MANN CAN FIX THE MESS

On February 28, the Chief Justice of India D.Y. Chandrachud and Justice P.S. Narasimha heard an unconventional case to sort out the running battle between Mann and Governor Banwarilal Purohit over their respective jurisdictions (see *Chief Minister vs Governor*). The SC justices issued a stern warning to both saying, "Political differences in a democratic polity are acceptable and have to be worked out with a sense of sobriety and maturity without allowing the discourse to degenerate to become a race to the bottom. Unless these principles were to be borne in mind, the effective implementation of the constitutional values is liable to be placed in jeopardy."

The SC's sound advice is what both the AAP government in the state and the BJP-ruled Centre must heed to prevent Punjab from spinning out of control as it did, with devastating consequences, in the '80s. In an encouraging move, Mann met Union home minister Amit Shah on March 2 to discuss the issue of radicalisation in the state. Many of the impulses that bred Sikh radicalism back then seem to be in play again. For one, as Pramod Kumar points out, Sikh dominance, both in terms of political and economic hegemony, is on the decline. That is largely because Punjab has become a buyer's market from a seller's one in agriculture, with the central government calling the shots. With agriculture, the mainstay of the state's economy, waning, given the fierce competition from other states, and industry not picking up either, both unemployment and disguised employment remain high in this once prosperous state. That is why it was the Punjab farmers who protested the most against the Modi government's new farm laws in 2020, and forced it to repeal them. So, rather than pushing the state to the edge, both Mann and Modi need to come up with a plan for Punjab's economic revival plan that can ensure rapid growth, even if it means the Centre waives some of the state's debt to ease the pressure. Mann too must